

Word family: **few / a few / fewer / fewest**

Base word: few

Comparative: fewer

Superlative: fewest

Important constructions: a few, very few, quite a few, a good few, the few, few and far between, no fewer than

Part of speech: determiner (限定詞) / pronoun (代名詞) / adjective-like quantifier (數量修飾語)

Your sentence:

> “**A few weeks later**, I bought the headphones, and they really lived up to the hype.”

A **full family sweep** here is quite compact: **few** does not have a large useful derivational family. The important learning value lies mainly in the contrast between **few** and **a few**, plus **fewer / fewest** and several common fixed expressions. I would not artificially add rare forms such as **fewness**.

Meaning in this passage

Here, **a few** means **a small number of weeks — more than one, but not many**.

繁體中文： **數量不多的幾個；這裡指過了幾個星期之後**

Natural translation:

> “A few weeks later, I bought the headphones...”

「**幾個星期後**，我買了那副耳機.....」

So:

a few weeks = 幾個星期 / 數星期

The important point is that **a few** normally has a fairly **neutral or positive** meaning:

> there were **some** weeks between the two events.

1. **a few + plural countable noun (可數複數名詞) — 幾個；一些；少量但確實有**

This is your original meaning.

****Meaning:**** A small number of people or things, but ****more than zero****.

Practice 1 — Original

> “****A few weeks later****, I bought the headphones.”

「****幾個星期後****，我買了那副耳機。」

Practice 2

> “I need ****a few minutes**** to finish this.”

「我需要****幾分鐘****把這件事完成。」

Practice 3

> “We invited ****a few friends**** over for dinner.”

「我們邀請了****幾個朋友****來家裡吃晚飯。」

****a few = 數量雖然不多，但確實有一些，通常不強調不足****

2. ****few + plural countable noun (可數複數名詞) — 很少；幾乎沒有****

This is one of the most important distinctions in English.

Without ****a****, ****few**** usually has a ****negative meaning****.

****Meaning:**** Not many; fewer than would be wanted, expected, or useful.

Practice 4

> “****Few people**** understood the instructions.”

「****很少人****明白那些指示。」

Practice 5

> “There are ****few opportunities**** for promotion.”

「晉升的機會****很少****。」

****few = 數量很少，往往帶有「少得不足 / 比預期少」的意味****

Critical distinction: **a few vs few**

This little **a** changes the meaning significantly.

a few

= some; a small number exists

> “I have **a few friends** here.”

「我在這裡**有幾個朋友**。」

The feeling is:

不是很多，但有。

few

= hardly any; not many enough

> “I have **few friends** here.”

「我在這裡**幾乎沒有甚麼朋友 / 朋友很少**。」

The feeling is:

少得令人注意，甚至可能不足。

For your sentence:

> **A few weeks later**

means simply:

幾個星期後

Not:

> **Few weeks later** ❌

That is not the normal construction for this meaning.

3. **a few** = a small number of people/things (代名詞) — 幾個；一些

Few does not always need a noun after it if the noun is already understood.

Practice 6

> “I took several photos, but only **a few** were good.”

「我拍了幾張照片，但只有**幾張**拍得好。」

Practice 7

> “We invited twenty people, but only **a few** came.”

「我們邀請了二十個人，但只有**幾個人**來了。」

a few — pronoun = 前文已經知道所指對象時，表示其中少量幾個

4. **few** = only a very small number (代名詞) — 很少人 / 很少幾個

Practice 8

> “Many applied, but **few** were accepted.”

「很多人申請，但**很少人**獲得取錄。」

Practice 9

> “The problem is complicated, and **few** understand it fully.”

「這個問題很複雜，**很少人**完全理解。」

few — pronoun = 所指群體中只有極少數符合某情況

5. **very few** + plural countable noun (可數複數名詞) — 非常少；極少

Very strengthens the negative small-number meaning.

Practice 10

> “**Very few** customers complained.”

「****極少顧客****作出投訴。」

Practice 11

> “Very ****few people**** can do this perfectly.”

「能夠把這件事做得完美的人****非常少****。」

****very few = 數量極少，只佔整體中很小的一部分****

6. ****quite a few + plural countable noun (可數複數名詞) — 相當多；不少****

This one surprises many learners.

****Quite a few does NOT mean very few.****

It actually means:

****a fairly large number / more than you might expect****

Practice 12

> “****Quite a few people**** attended the event.”

「有****相當多人 / 不少人****參加了活動。」

Practice 13

> “I’ve watched that film ****quite a few times****.”

「那套電影我已經看過****不少次****了。」

****quite a few = 數量相當多，比單純的 a few 明顯更多****

Compare:

* ****a few people**** = 幾個人

* ****quite a few people**** = 不少人 / 相當多人

* ****very few people**** = 極少人

This is an excellent MCQ trap.

7. **a good few + plural countable noun** (可數複數名詞) — 相當多；不少

Especially common in British English.

Practice 14

> “It took **a good few hours** to finish.”

「完成這件事花了**相當幾個小時 / 好幾個小時**。」

Practice 15

> “I’ve been there **a good few times**.”

「我已經去過那裡**好幾次 / 不少次**。」

a good few = 數量比普通 **a few** 多，表示「好幾個 / 相當多」

8. **fewer + plural countable noun** (可數複數名詞) — 較少的；更少的

Fewer is the comparative form of **few**.

Practice 16

> “This model has **fewer buttons**.”

「這個型號的按鈕**較少**。」

Practice 17

> “Fewer people attended this year.”

「今年參加的人**比之前少**。」

fewer = 比另一個數量更少，用於可數名詞

9. **fewer than + number** (數字) — 少於.....

Practice 18

> “**Fewer than ten people** attended the meeting.”

「參加會議的**不足十人**。」

Practice 19

> “The repair took **fewer than three hours**.”

「維修用了**不到三個小時**。」

****fewer than = 數量少於某個數字****

10. ****fewest + plural countable noun (可數複數名詞) — 最少的****

****Fewest**** is the superlative form.

Practice 20

> “This option has the ****fewest problems****.”

「這個選項的問題****最少****。」

Practice 21

> “Which team made the ****fewest mistakes****?”

「哪一隊犯的錯誤****最少****？」

****fewest = 在三個或以上的比較對象中，數量最少****

11. ****the few = the small number of people/things that exist/remain — 少數；僅有的少數人 / 事物****

Practice 22

> “She was one of ****the few**** who supported the idea.”

「她是支持這個想法的****少數人之一****。」

Practice 23

> “These are among ****the few**** buildings that survived.”

「這些是少數**保存下來的建築物**之一。」

****the few = 某個群體中數量非常有限的那一小部分****

12. ****one of the few + plural noun + who/that... — 少數……之一****

A very common pattern.

Practice 24

> “He is ****one of the few people who**** knows the full story.”

「他是****少數知道整件事真相的人之一****。」

Practice 25

> “This is ****one of the few restaurants that**** stays open late.”

「這是****少數會營業至深夜的餐廳之一****。」

****one of the few... = 在符合某項條件的人 / 事物之中，只有極少數，而主語是其中之一****

Grammar note:

> ****one of the few people who know**** 

because ****who**** refers to plural ****people****.

13. ****few and far between = very rare / uncommon — 非常罕見；寥寥可數****

This is an important fixed expression.

Practice 26

> “Cheap apartments in this area are ****few and far between****.”

「這個地區便宜的公寓****非常罕見 / 寥寥可數****。」

Practice 27

> “Truly excellent products are ****few and far between****.”

「真正出色的產品**並不常見 / 少之又少**。」

****few and far between = 數量很少，而且彼此之間間隔很大；引申為非常罕見****

14. ****no fewer than + number (數字) — 多達；竟有.....之多****

This expression can look confusing because it contains ****fewer****, but its practical meaning emphasizes a surprisingly ****large**** number.

Practice 28

> “No fewer than fifty people applied.”

「****多達五十人****提出申請。」

Practice 29

> “The book has been translated into ****no fewer than twenty languages****.”

「這本書已被翻譯成****多達二十種語言****。」

****no fewer than = 數量不少於某個數字，常用來強調數量之多****

Compare:

> ****fewer than 20**** = 少於 20

> ****no fewer than 20**** = 不少於 20；多達 20

15. ****not a few = many / quite a lot (較正式) — 不少；相當多****

This is more formal/literary.

Practice 30

> “The decision caused ****not a few problems****.”

「這項決定造成了****不少問題****。」

Practice 31

> “Not a few people disagreed with the proposal.”

「**不少人**不同意這項建議。」

not a few = 並非只有少數，即「不少 / 相當多」

In everyday conversation, **quite a few** is usually more natural.

16. **few, if any = extremely few, possibly none — 即使有也極少；可能根本沒有**

A useful formal/academic expression.

Practice 32

> “Few, if any, customers noticed the difference.”

「**即使有顧客注意到差別，人數也極少**；甚至可能沒有人注意到。」

Practice 33

> “There are few, if any, simple solutions.”

「簡單的解決方法**即使有也極少，甚至可能根本沒有**。」

few, if any = 數量極少，而且實際數量可能是零

Important distinction: **few vs a few**

This is the single most important distinction.

Expression	Core meaning	Traditional Chinese
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few	hardly any; insufficiently small number	很少；幾乎沒有
a few	some; a small number exists	幾個；一些
very few	an extremely small number	極少
quite a few	a fairly large number	不少；相當多

Compare:

> “I have **few books**.”

「我的書**很少**。」

→ emphasizes shortage.

> “I have **a few books**.”

「我有**幾本書**。」

→ some exist.

> “I have **quite a few books**.”

「我有**不少書**。」

One tiny article creates a major meaning difference.

Important distinction: **few vs little**

Both can mean 「少」, but the noun type is different.

few / a few

with **countable plural nouns**

* a few weeks

* few people

* fewer problems

little / a little

with **uncountable nouns**

* a little time

* little money

* less water

Compare:

> “I have **a few minutes**.”

「我有**幾分鐘**。」

> “I have **a little time**.”

「我有一**點時間**。」

Important distinction: **fewer vs less**

Traditional grammar distinction:

fewer

for countable things

> “fewer customers”

「較少顧客」

less

for uncountable quantities

> “less noise”

「較少噪音」

So:

> **fewer people** 

> **less water** 

In everyday English, **less** also appears with certain measurements and numbers:

* less than 10 minutes

* less than \$20

* less than five kilometres

because these are often treated as **amounts**, not individually counted units.

Important distinction: **a few vs several**

a few

= a small number

several

= more than two, generally suggesting somewhat more than **a few**

But English does not give them exact numerical boundaries.

> “I stayed for a few days.”

= 我逗留了幾天。

> “I stayed for several days.”

= 我逗留了好幾天 / 數天。

Several often feels a little larger.

Important distinction: a few vs some

a few

specifically emphasizes a **small number of countable things**

some

is broader and does not necessarily emphasize smallness.

> “I invited a few friends.”

= 我邀請了幾個朋友。

> “I invited some friends.”

= 我邀請了一些朋友。

The second does not tell us as clearly that the number was small.

Important grammar note: few is for countable nouns

Correct:

> **a few weeks** ✓

> **few customers** ✓

> **fewer mistakes** ✓

Not normally:

> **a few time** ✗

> **few money** ✗

Instead:

> **a little time**

> **little money**

Family-extension sweep

For this family, the genuinely useful forms and expressions are:

* **few** = 很少；幾乎沒有

* **a few** = 幾個；一些

* **very few** = 極少

* **quite a few** = 不少；相當多

* **a good few** = 好幾個；相當多

* **fewer** = 較少

* **fewest** = 最少

* **the few** = 少數的人 / 事物

* **one of the few** = 少數.....之一

* **few and far between** = 非常罕見

* **no fewer than** = 多達；不少於

* **not a few** = 不少（較正式）

* **few, if any** = 即使有也極少

There is a noun **fewness**, but it is uncommon enough that I would **not** include it in a normal learner's active vocabulary. That is exactly where our rule “search broadly, include conservatively” matters.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
a few + plural noun	數量不多但確實存在的一些人 / 事物；幾個
few + plural noun	數量很少，往往帶有不足或比預期少的意味
a few — pronoun	前文對象已清楚時，指其中少量幾個
few — pronoun	某個群體中只有極少數符合某情況
very few	數量極少，只佔整體很小部分
quite a few	數量相當多，比普通 a few 明顯更多
a good few	好幾個 / 相當多，尤其常見於英式英語
fewer	與另一數量相比，可數的人 / 事物較少
fewest	在多個比較對象中，可數的人 / 事物數量最少
the few	某群體中數量非常有限的那一小部分

one of the few	在只有極少數符合某條件的人 / 事物中，其中之一	
few and far between	數量極少而不常出現；非常罕見	
no fewer than	不少於某個數字，常用來強調數量之多	
not a few	並非少數，即不少 / 相當多；較正式	
few, if any	數量即使不是零也極少	

For your original sentence

> **A few weeks later**, I bought the headphones...

The exact meaning is:

a few = 一個不大的數量，但確實有幾個

Therefore:

> **a few weeks later**

= **幾個星期後 / 數星期後**

And the crucial distinction is:

> **a few weeks** = 幾個星期

> **few weeks** = 很少幾個星期；通常不能直接代替你句子中的 **a few weeks**

So here, **a few** is neutral: it simply tells us that **a small number of weeks** passed before the speaker bought the headphones.